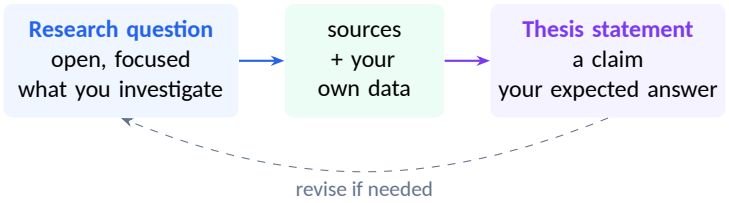
Worksheet W4 · W-Seminar "Time"

# Research question and thesis

From a topic to a question you can answer – and to the claim you will put to the test.

## 1 A question and its answer




**Now:** a *working thesis* – for an experiment or survey your *hypothesis*.
**End of 12/1:** question fixed.
**Final paper:** thesis backed by your results.

In your own words: how do question and thesis work together?

## 2 Six markers of a good research question

**Focused** Who or what exactly? Where, when?
**Open** no one-search answer, no plain yes/no, no built-in answer
**Researchable** Are there sources to build on?
Open question words: *How … / To what extent … / In what ways … / Why …*

**Testable** Can I collect my own data?
**Feasible** 10–15 pages? Time, access, ethics?
**Relevant** So what? And is it about time?

## 3 Spot the problem

Which marker does each question miss most? Then improve one of them.

| question | missing marker |
|---|---|
| a) What is the Mayan calendar? | |
| b) How does time affect people? | |
| c) Will humans ever travel back in time? | |
| d) How did all English novels of the 20th century deal with time? | |

My improved version of _____ :

## 4 From question to thesis

A thesis statement …

- **answers** the question directly
- is **arguable** – not a fact, not a taste
- is **specific** – group, material, direction
- is **testable** – a result could prove it wrong
- is **short** – one or two sentences

**Question:** To what extent does checking a phone during homework change how long students think they worked?

Your working thesis:

## 5 Work phase: read to orient

10 min · aim for 1–3 options by the end of today

My spark: _____

Keywords (English): _____

Names (researchers, authors, works): _____

A debate – where do people disagree? _____

strategies + builder

## 6 Question storm

5 min · at least 10 questions · no judging · then mark O (open) / C (closed) and star your best three

_____

_____

_____

_____

## 7 My options

| | research question | working thesis | my own data – from whom? |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | | | |
| 2 | | | |
| 3 | | | |

## 8 Draw the line – for your strongest option

**In** material · people · time span · aspect · method

**Out – on purpose**

_____ _____

_____ _____

_____ _____

This paper focuses on _____

It does not _____

## 9 Partner check

- ☐ So what – who would want to know?
- ☐ What exactly will you collect, from whom?
- ☐ Which result would prove your thesis wrong?
- ☐ Too big, too small – or right for 10–15 pages?

My partner's tip · my next step

_____

_____